



Unit 2:

Independent Project

Unit code: 70726U

Unit level: 6

Credit value: 30

Introduction

The ability to plan, manage and deliver a substantial student-led project is a vital skill for graduates entering the modern workplace. Whether pursuing employment, launching a business, or progressing to further study, professionals are expected to solve complex problems, take initiative and communicate evidence-based ideas with clarity. This unit provides the opportunity to demonstrate subject-knowledge, project management and critical thinking; all essential qualities for employment in digital-based industries.

It supports skill development by guiding students through the complete lifecycle of a research or practice-based project, from idea generation to final delivery and reflection. Students will begin by identifying a complex problem, challenge or opportunity relevant to their chosen specialism within the digital economy. They will then define clear aims and objectives, carry out detailed planning and apply appropriate research and project management techniques. Alongside this, they will gather and analyse data to generate insights and evidence and present their findings in both written and verbal formats suited to a professional audience.

The independent project showcases both academic achievement and mirrors the expectations of professional practice. This unit is designed to encourage independent thinking and responsibility by providing structure and guidance. Students will learn to manage risks, work to deadlines and make informed decisions under pressure. Importantly, they will also be encouraged to reflect on their personal and professional development by identifying the skills they've gained and areas they can continue to improve. These are key behaviours expected by employers in graduate roles and are essential for success in freelance, entrepreneurial, or innovation-driven environments.

By completing this unit, students will strengthen their ability to deliver professional-standard work autonomously, communicate their ideas clearly and engage critically with challenges in their field. These are essential foundations for successful employment or further study, and will position students to contribute meaningfully in a rapidly evolving digital workforce.



Note on Project Format:

This unit is designed to accommodate both research-based and practice-based approaches. Students may undertake either a **thesis-style project**, which focuses on academic research and critical inquiry, or a **capstone-style project**, which emphasises practical application and solution development within a professional context. The choice of format should reflect the student's academic interests, career goals, and the expectations of their chosen specialism within the digital technologies sector.



Learning Outcomes

By the end of this unit a student will be able to:

- LO1 Develop a project proposal that addresses a complex problem or opportunity within a defined digital technologies context
- LO2 Deliver a project using appropriately selected tools, methods and ethical frameworks to achieve project outcomes
- LO3 Generate evidence-based insights from relevant data aligned with defined project objectives
- LO4 Communicate project outcomes in professional written and verbal formats, including a reflective evaluation of personal and professional development.

Essential Content

LO1 **Develop a project proposal that addresses a complex problem or opportunity within a defined digital technologies context**

Identifying problem or opportunity:

Characteristics of a complex problem (for e.g. multi-variable, uncertain, real-world relevance, gap in the literature and/or industry)

Perspectives and expectations of relevant stakeholders

Communicate project proposal clearly, using appropriate structure, academic tone and referencing conventions.

Defining research aim, objectives and questions:

Purpose of project proposal to define a clear aim that sets the direction for all subsequent project decisions

Goal-setting frameworks (for e.g. SMART) to define research objectives that reflect complexity, scope and intended outcomes of the project

Hypothesis formulation and scope definition.

Reviewing literature and prior work:

Conduct a critical literature review using academic journals, white papers and industry reports

Apply appropriate theoretical frameworks to structure and inform methodology

Identify gaps in knowledge or practice from academic and/or industry sources.

Ethical and feasibility considerations:

Consideration of research ethics (for e.g. informed consent, data privacy, bias mitigation)

Feasibility analysis (time, access to data, resources, skills).

Justifying the research direction:

Compare alternative approaches or topics

Align project proposal with academic, industry and personal development

Define scope boundaries and acknowledge potential constraints (for e.g. deadlines, restricted access, technical constraints, or scale of expected outcomes).



LO2 Deliver a project using appropriately selected tools, methods and ethical frameworks to achieve project outcomes

Project planning requirements and techniques:

Tools for planning (for e.g. work breakdown structures, Gantt charts, Kanban boards)

Create project schedules showing clear start/end dates, dependencies, milestone setting, contingency time and checkpoints (for e.g. critical path analysis) to identify the sequence of crucial steps and milestones for project completion

Suitability of planning tools (for e.g. Gantt charts, Kanban, critical path analysis) for complex project environments

Resource planning including human, digital, technical and financial resources needed to complete the project

Identify common project risks and propose mitigation strategies for (e.g. risk registers, contingency planning).

Methodologies and frameworks:

Progress tracking tools for project management (for e.g. Trello, Jira, MS Project, Monday.com, Asana)

Documentation and audit trails (for e.g. project logbook, reflective journal) for recording decisions, iterations and stakeholder feedback to achieve project outcomes

Suitable choice of methodological approach (for e.g. agile, scrum, PRINCE2 (Projects in Controlled Environments), waterfall) based on project type relevant to sector standards

Plan for managing ethical issues relevant to the project (for e.g. data privacy, informed consent, intellectual property) and compliance with relevant codes or policies (for e.g. General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), institutional ethics procedures).



LO3 **Generate evidence-based insights from relevant data aligned with defined project objectives**

Data collection methods:

Primary data collection (for e.g. surveys, interviews, observations, experiments)

Secondary data collection (for e.g. databases, open datasets, internal reports)

Sampling strategies (for e.g. random, stratified, purposive).

Analytical techniques and presenting of data:

Quantitative (for e.g. descriptive statistics such as mean and standard deviation; inferential tests such as t-tests and chi-square; regression techniques such as linear regression)

Qualitative (for e.g. thematic analysis, coding, narrative synthesis)

Select tools to support analysis of data appropriate to the scale and nature of project (for e.g. Excel, SPSS, R, Python, NVivo, PowerBI)

Select and apply data presentation and visualisation techniques (for e.g. charts, dashboards, infographics) for interpreting trends, anomalies and correlations

Draw conclusions by linking findings to defined project objectives and acknowledge limitations to make suggestions for future research.

Validity, reliability and effectiveness:

Evaluate whether choice of data and methods accurately measured or represented intended variables or concepts (i.e. validity)

Assess how factors such as sample size, data quality and research design influenced results, and consider the consistency and repeatability of findings (i.e. reliability)

Use evaluation techniques (for e.g. post-project review, project health checks, Red Amber Green (RAG) ratings) to assess how well the project met its planned objectives, timelines and resource allocations

Review how well risks were anticipated, mitigated or responded during project delivery.



LO4 Communicate project outcomes in professional written and verbal formats, including a reflective evaluation of personal and professional development

Report writing:

Structure of report to include abstract, introduction, methodology, findings, discussion, conclusion, references/sources cited and, if relevant, appendices

Use academic writing conventions and citation styles (for e.g. Harvard (author-date), Numerical (numbered reference)).

Presentation skills:

Design effective visuals (for e.g. slides, prototypes, demonstrations) suitable for intended audience

Use verbal delivery techniques including clarity, pacing and engagement suitable for intended audience.

Reflective practice:

Apply advanced reflective models (for e.g. Gibbs' reflective cycle, Kolb's experimental learning cycle, Schon's reflection model) to evaluate personal growth, skill development and challenges faced

Identify transferable skills gained (for e.g. leadership, communication, resilience)

Use audit tools (for e.g. SWOT (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats), skills matrix, 360 feedback) to identify personal strengths; multi-source feedback from peers, supervisors and self; and areas for improvement

Make suggestions for planning next steps, career goals, further study and/or portfolio development.

Learning Outcomes and Assessment Criteria

Pass	Merit	Distinction
L01 Develop a project proposal that addresses a complex problem or opportunity within a defined digital technologies context.		D1 Evaluate alternative approaches for research direction of the proposed project, with reference to wider contexts.
P1 Construct a clear aim and objectives for the proposed project addressing a complex problem or opportunity. P2 Discuss the significance of the proposed project in relation to its digital technologies context.	M1 Justify the relevance, feasibility and significance of the proposed project evidenced using academic and/or industry sources.	
L02 Deliver a project using appropriately selected tools, methods and ethical frameworks to achieve project outcomes.		D2 Critically assess the effectiveness of project planning and management, providing improvements informed by lessons learned.
P3 Produce a structured project plan including timelines, resource needs, risks and ethical considerations. P4 Implement key elements of the project plan to achieve defined outcomes.	M2 Monitor project progress using appropriate tools and respond to emerging challenges in line with project objectives.	
L03 Generate evidence-based insights from relevant data aligned with defined project objectives.		D3 Evaluate the validity and reliability of evidence-based findings and insights, proposing implications for future personal and professional development.
P5 Apply selected data collection and analysis methods to generate findings and initial insights aligned with project objectives.	M3 Interpret appropriate data collection and analysis methods aligned with defined project objectives. M4 Compare patterns or trends in data to draw reasoned conclusions, supported by appropriate visualisation.	



Pass	Merit	Distinction
LO4 Communicate project outcomes in professional written and verbal formats, including a reflective evaluation of personal and professional development.		D4 Critically review personal and professional development using evidence from the project, proposing strategies for future growth.
P6 Present project outcomes in a structured report and oral presentation using appropriate formats. P7 Review on personal and professional development using a recognised reflective model, identifying strengths and areas for improvement.	M5 Communicate project outcomes tailored to a professional audience, with appropriate use of visual and written media and accurate use of academic citation conventions.	

Recommended Resources

Textbooks

Bell, E., Harley, B. and Bryman, A. (2022). *Business Research Methods*. 6th edn. Oxford University Press.

Bell, J. and Waters, S. (2024). *Doing Your Research Project: A Guide for First-Time Researchers*. 8th edn. Open University Press.

Brookfield, C. and Lewis, J. (2025). *Completing your Research Project: A Guide for the Social Sciences*. SAGE.

Cottrell, S. (2021). *The Study Skills Handbook*. 5th edn. Bloomsbury Academic.

Oates, B.J., Griffiths, M. and McLean, R. (2022). *Researching Information Systems and Computing*. SAGE.

Saunders, M., Lewis, P. and Thornhill, A. (2023). *Research Methods for Business Students*. 9th edn. Pearson.

Websites

pmi.org

Project Management Institute
PMBOK Guide
(General Reference)

Journals and articles

Elsevier. (2025). *International Journal of Project Management* [online]. Available at: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-journal-of-project-management> (Accessed: 21 August 2025)

Elsevier. (2025). *Journal of Business Research* [online]. Available at: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-business-research> (Accessed: 21 August 2025)

Taylor & Francis. (2025). *Journal of Education and Work* [online]. Available at: <https://www.tandfonline.com/journals/cjew20> (Accessed: 21 August 2025)

Taylor & Francis. (2025). *Studies in Higher Education* [online]. Available at: <https://www.tandfonline.com/journals/cshe20> (Accessed: 21 August 2025)